South Island Self-Drive

Christchurch → Arthur's Pass → Glacier Country → Haast Pass → Wānaka → Aoraki/Mount Cook → Lake Tekapo → Queenstown → Milford Road → Queenstown

Two adults, one driver, Sat 6 March to Sun 14 March 2027 (8 nights). Prepared 9 November 2026. Planning only: nothing has been booked or contacted.

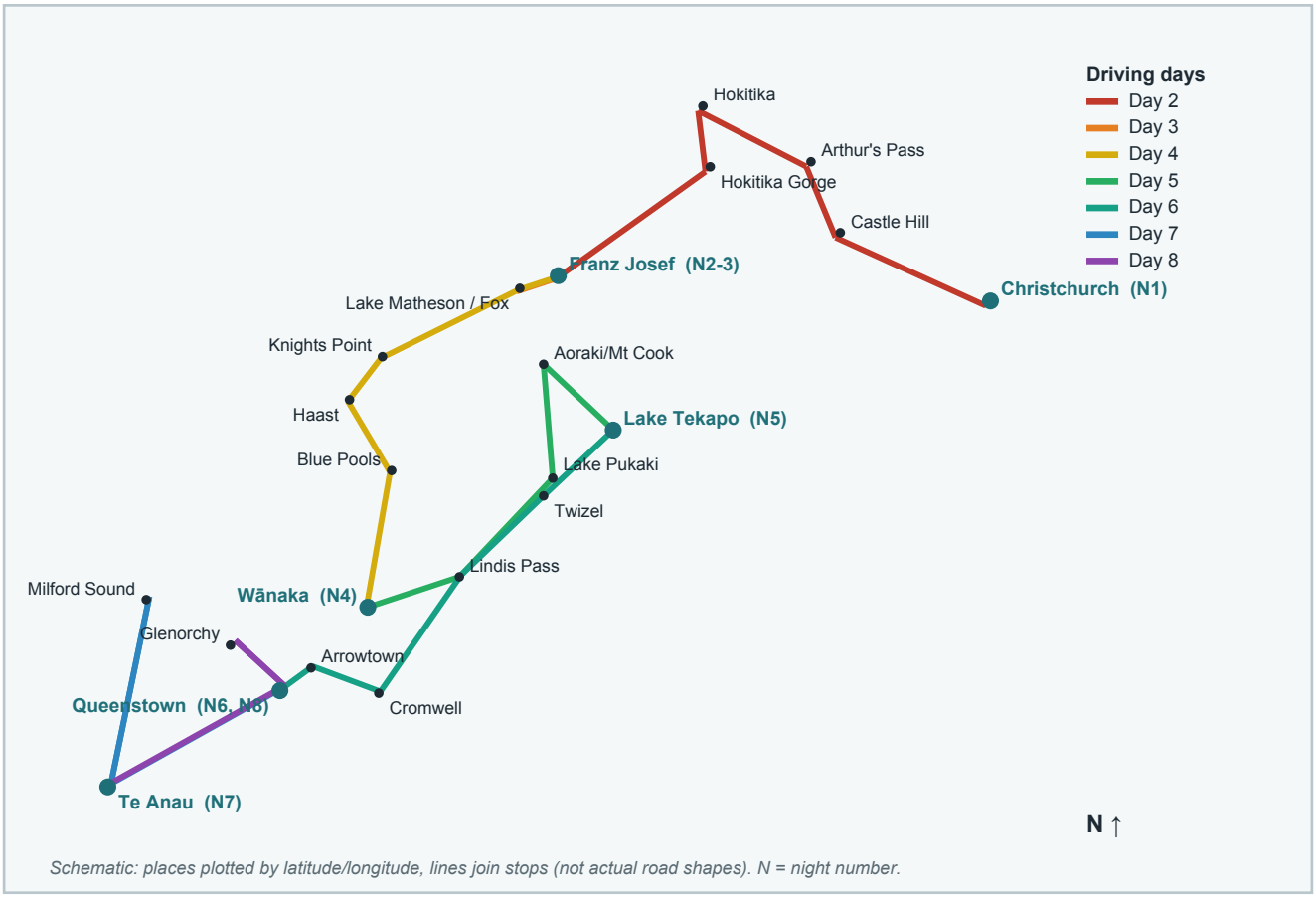
The plan in one paragraph. Cross the Southern Alps by Arthur's Pass, spend two nights at Franz Josef for the glaciers (with a spare half-day for helicopter weather), go over Haast Pass to Wānaka, see Aoraki/Mount Cook on the way to an Accor night at Lake Tekapo, then base in Queenstown. A Te Anau night makes the Milford Road possible without breaking your 500 km limit. You get the mountains, lakes, glaciers and the best road-accessible wildlife (kea, kiwi, takahē, penguins), with **no boats, no beach walks, no walk longer than about 2 hours**, every day under 500 km, and every arrival at least 1¼ hours before sunset. Four of the eight nights are Accor (the most the route allows).

Trip at a glance

Day	Date	Route (overnight in bold)	Drive	Leave / arrive	Sunset
1	Sat 6 Mar	Land CHC 14:30, collect car, Antarctic Centre (penguins). **Christchurch Airport**	~5 km	15:45 / 16:00	20:08
2	Sun 7 Mar	Castle Hill, Arthur's Pass, Hokitika, Hokitika Gorge → **Franz Josef**	440 km, ~6¾ h	07:20 / ~17:15	20:16
3	Mon 8 Mar	Lake Matheson, Fox and Franz Josef glaciers, glacier flight, kiwi centre. **Franz Josef**	~70 km, ~1½ h	07:35 / ~16:30	20:14
4	Tue 9 Mar	Knights Point, Haast Pass waterfalls, Blue Pools, Lake Hāwea → **Wānaka**	288 km, ~4½ h	08:15 / ~16:15	20:17
5	Wed 10 Mar	Lindis Pass, Lake Pukaki, Aoraki/Mount Cook walks → **Lake Tekapo**	~340 km, ~5 h	08:45 / ~18:10	20:11
6	Thu 11 Mar	Mt John, Lindis Pass, Cromwell, Kawarau Gorge, Arrowtown → **Queenstown**	~270 km, ~4¼ h	10:00 / ~15:30	20:16
7	Fri 12 Mar	Te Anau, Milford Road, Milford Sound (from shore) → **Te Anau**	410 km, ~6½ h	07:40 / ~16:30	20:18
8	Sat 13 Mar	Devil's Staircase, Queenstown, Glenorchy road → **Queenstown**	~265 km, ~4 h	08:30 / ~15:30	20:12
9	Sun 14 Mar	Return car at Queenstown Airport ~08:30; fly 11:00. No sightseeing.	7 km	08:15 / 08:30	n/a

Total driving about 2,100 km. Drive times are road-routing estimates (OSRM, OpenStreetMap data) plus about 15% for winding mountain roads, one-lane bridges and roadworks. They don't include stops; the day plans do. Sunset times are calculated for each overnight town (NZ Daylight Time, UTC+13, which runs until 4 April 2027). In deep valleys such as Milford and Mount Cook the sun drops behind the ridges earlier, which is why every plan arrives well before sunset.

Route map



Schematic: places plotted by latitude/longitude, lines join stops (not actual road shapes). N = night number.

Why this route

- **Both sides of the Alps.** You asked for as much as possible. Arthur's Pass and the West Coast give you the glaciers and rainforest; Haast Pass, Wānaka and Mount Cook give you the big lakes and the highest peaks. The coast-only or inland-only versions each drop one of your four interests.
- **Two nights at Franz Josef.** Glacier flights are often cancelled for cloud or rain. A full day there, plus an early slot on Day 4, gives you two chances.
- **Te Anau on the night of 12 March.** A Queenstown–Milford–Queenstown day trip is about 575 km, which is over your 500 km limit, and the drive back would end near dark. From Te Anau, the Milford round trip is 240 km. A Te Anau night on 13 March doesn't work either: getting to the airport for an 11:00 flight would mean leaving before sunrise. So Te Anau has to be night 7, and night 8 is Queenstown.
- **Tekapo, not Mount Cook village, on night 5.** Mount Cook village has no Accor hotel and few rooms under NZ$300. Tekapo has two Accor properties and is only 1¼ h from the Mount Cook walks, so you still get a full afternoon at Aoraki. This gives you 4 Accor nights instead of 3.
- **What repeats.** The Lindis Pass and Twizel–Omarama stretch (about 170 km) is driven twice, on Days 5 and 6. Every alternative repeats more, for example Haast Pass both ways (about 290 km), because the West Coast is a dead end for a one-way Christchurch to Queenstown trip.

Left out on purpose

- All boat trips: Milford and Doubtful Sound cruises, Tasman Lake glacier boats, Te Anau glowworm caves (reached by boat), the TSS Earnslaw, Shotover Jet, and Kaikōura whale watching.
- Beaches and beach walks, including Monro Beach (penguins, but a beach walk), Ship Creek, Gillespies Beach and the Punakaiki coast.
- Walks over about 2 hours: Hooker Valley to the lake (3 h), Roys Peak (5–6 h), Key Summit (3 h), Rob Roy Glacier (3–4 h), Ben Lomond.
- Kaikōura, Akaroa, Dunedin and the Catlins. Each needs 1–2 extra days and is mainly coastal or boat-based.

What I assumed where you didn't say

Topic	Assumption I made	If that's wrong
Passports	You both hold Australian passports or Australian permanent residence (the driver has an Australian licence), so no NZeTA is needed.	Other passports usually need an NZeTA plus the visitor levy before flying. Apply online at least 72 h ahead.
Arrival on 6 Mar	An international arrival from Australia at 14:30, so you're out of biosecurity and customs and at the car desk by about 15:30.	If it's a domestic flight you'll be out by about 15:00, which gives more time at the Antarctic Centre.
Flight on 14 Mar	Treated as international, so you should be at the airport 2 h early (09:00).	If domestic, 60 min is enough and you can leave the hotel later.
Vehicle	An automatic compact SUV or mid-size car rented one-way from Christchurch Airport to Queenstown Airport, with only the one named driver.	A campervan would change the accommodation, the drive times and the one-way fees.
"Never drive after dark"	No driving before sunrise or after sunset. Every plan arrives at least 75 min before sunset, and none leaves before sunrise.	
Budget	NZ$300 per room per night including GST, for one room with two beds.	
Fitness and health	Both comfortable on walks of up to about 2 hours on formed tracks. No dietary or mobility needs.	Shorter options are noted for every long walk.
Stargazing and scenic flights	Offered as optional extras. They fit "mountains and glaciers" but you didn't ask for them.	Leave them out and the plan still works.
Travel insurance	Not mentioned. I recommend a policy that also covers the rental-car excess.	

Day-by-day plan

Times are a guide for an early-start pace. The "cut" line on each long day tells you what to drop if you're running late, so the arrival stays well before sunset.

Day 1 · Sat 6 Mar · Arrive Christchurch

Drive: about 5 km. Sunrise 07:14, sunset 20:08. Overnight: Novotel Christchurch Airport (Accor).

Time	What	Notes
14:30	Land at Christchurch (CHC)	NZ biosecurity is strict. Declare food, and clean the soil off hiking boots before you fly.
~15:30	Collect the one-way rental car	Check the car for damage and photograph it. Confirm the drop-off is Queenstown Airport, Sun 14 Mar, 08:30.
15:45	Check in at Novotel Christchurch Airport	Across the road from the terminal.
16:00–17:15	International Antarctic Centre (optional)	About 5 min from the hotel. Rescued little blue penguins (kororā). Closing time is listed as 16:30 or 17:30 depending on the source, so check on the day. Roughly NZ$50–75 per adult.
17:30	Supermarket and fuel	Buy water, snacks and a picnic lunch for tomorrow. Make sure the car has a full tank.
Evening	Early dinner and early night	Tomorrow is the longest day and starts at 07:20.

Day 2 · Sun 7 Mar · Arthur's Pass to Glacier Country

Drive: about 440 km, about 6¾ h at the wheel. This is the longest day; take a break at least every 2 h. Sunrise 07:15 (Christchurch), sunset 20:16 (Franz Josef). Overnight: Franz Josef (no Accor in town).

Time	What	Notes
07:20	Leave Christchurch on SH73	Fuel at Springfield if needed. There's no reliable fuel until the West Coast.
08:35–09:10	Kura Tawhiti / Castle Hill	Limestone boulder field with mountain backdrop. 30 min of easy wandering.
09:45–11:00	Arthur's Pass village	Devil's Punchbowl Falls walk (131 m waterfall, about 1 h return). Look out for kea, the alpine parrot, around the village. Don't feed them, and keep car doors closed.
11:10	Otira Viaduct Lookout	10 min stop. Kea are often in the car park here too.
12:40–13:30	Hokitika: lunch	Optional National Kiwi Centre (kiwi and giant eels, about 45 min) only if you're ahead of time. Fill the tank.
14:05–14:45	Hokitika Gorge	Milky-turquoise river, a swing bridge and lookouts. About 20–40 min of walking.
~17:15	Arrive Franz Josef	About 3 h before sunset.

- **Cut:** if you haven't left Hokitika by 14:30, skip Hokitika Gorge. That saves about 65 km and 1¼ h, and the day becomes 375 km.
- Mobile coverage is patchy on Arthur's Pass. Download offline Google Maps for the whole South Island before you leave.

Day 3 · Mon 8 Mar · Glaciers, mirror lake, kiwi

Drive: about 70 km in short hops. Sunrise 07:26, sunset 20:14. Overnight: Franz Josef again.

Time	What	Notes
07:35–08:10	Drive to Lake Matheson (29 km)	Calm early-morning water gives the famous reflection of Aoraki/Mt Cook and Mt Tasman.
08:10–09:40	Lake Matheson / Te Ara Kairaumati loop	About 1½ h, flat, through rainforest. Breakfast at the café by the car park afterwards.
10:10–10:50	Fox Glacier South Side Walkway, to the first viewpoint	The first glacier view is about 10 min in. The full walk is about 2 h return, so only do it if you're skipping the flight.
12:00–13:00	Glacier scenic flight with snow landing (optional)	Helicopter, about 20–40 min, landing on the névé high above Franz Josef and/or Fox. Roughly NZ$350–550 per person. Book a midday slot with free rebooking, and use the Day 4 08:00 slot as backup. It's fine for someone who gets seasick on boats, but bring travel-sickness tablets if unsure.
14:00–15:30	Franz Josef Glacier / Kā Roimata o Hine Hukatere Walk	About 5.4 km, about 1½ h return, up the valley floor towards the terminal face. It closes after heavy rain, so check the DOC sign at the car park. Add Sentinel Rock (20 min) or Peters Pool (15 min) if you have time.
16:00–17:00	West Coast Wildlife Centre, Franz Josef	Rowi and Haast tokoeka, the two rarest kiwi. Open 08:30–18:00. Entry roughly NZ$40 per person; the 40-min backstage tour (hatchery and tuatara) costs extra and should be booked a few days ahead.
Evening	Glacier Hot Pools (optional, walk from town)	No driving after about 17:00.

- **Rainy day plan** (the West Coast gets heavy rain): the Wildlife Centre, Hot Pools and both glacier valley walks in light rain. Move the flight to Day 4 morning.
- The DOC car parks at the glacier walks have trialled parking fees. Pay by card if the machines are running.

Day 4 · Tue 9 Mar · Haast Pass to Wānaka

Drive: about 288 km, about 4½ h. Sunrise 07:27, sunset 20:17 (Wānaka). Overnight: Wānaka (no confirmed Accor hotel; see Accommodation).

Time	What	Notes
08:15	Leave Franz Josef (or ~09:30 if using the backup flight slot)	Fill the tank in Franz Josef or Fox.
10:00–10:15	Knights Point Lookout	Clifftop view of the Tasman coast. Fur seals are often visible on the rocks below. It's a car-park lookout with no beach walking.
10:40–11:00	Haast	Fuel up. It's about 140 km to Wānaka with only a small, pricier pump at Makarora.
11:30–12:30	Haast Pass waterfalls	Roaring Billy Falls (25 min return), Thunder Creek Falls (5 min) and Fantail Falls (5 min).
13:00–14:15	Blue Pools Walk with picnic lunch	About 1 h return. Two swing bridges over glacier-blue river pools. Use insect repellent for the sandflies.
15:15	The Neck lookouts	Lake Hāwea on one side and Lake Wānaka on the other.
~16:15	Arrive Wānaka	Walk the lakeside path to #ThatWanakaTree. It's best in the golden light before the 20:17 sunset, and you won't need the car.

Day 5 · Wed 10 Mar · Lindis Pass, Aoraki/Mount Cook, Lake Tekapo

Drive: about 340 km, about 5 h. Sunrise 07:32 (Wānaka), sunset 20:11 (Tekapo). Overnight: Peppers Bluewater Resort or Mantra Lake Tekapo (both Accor).

Time	What	Notes
07:35–08:35	Mt Iron (optional)	About 1 h return from the car park, 2 min from town. 360° lookout over Wānaka and the mountains.
08:45	Leave Wānaka on SH6 and SH8	
09:50	Lindis Pass summit lookout	Golden tussock high country, 971 m.
10:50–11:15	Lake Pukaki visitor centre and Peter's Lookout	Turquoise lake with Aoraki at the end of it. Also a salmon shop.
12:00–12:30	Arrive Aoraki/Mount Cook village; lunch	Fill up in Twizel or Tekapo, not here: fuel at the village is limited.
12:40–14:10	Hooker Valley Track, to the second swing bridge and back	From the White Horse Hill car park, the first bridge is 15 min in. Going to the second bridge and back takes about 1½ h. The full walk to Hooker Lake is about 3 h return, so it's over your limit. Parking costs NZ$2.50 per half hour, card only.
14:20–15:20	Kea Point Track	About 1 h return from the same car park. Viewing deck over the Mueller Glacier lake, Mt Sefton and Aoraki.
15:35–16:30	Tasman Glacier View	Drive 8 km up the Tasman Valley Road. A 40-min return climb (past the Blue Lakes) looks over the Tasman Glacier's terminal lake and moraine. Skip the boat trips here.
16:45–18:10	Drive to Lake Tekapo (104 km)	Arrive about 2 h before sunset.
~22:00	Dark Sky Project stargazing tour (optional)	The operator drives you up Mt John, so you don't drive after dark. Book a few weeks ahead.

- **Weather swap:** check the forecast on the evening of Day 4. If Aoraki will be in cloud on the 10th but clear on the 11th, do it the other way round. Day 5 becomes Wānaka → Pukaki → Tekapo (about 230 km). Day 6 becomes Tekapo → Mount Cook walks → Queenstown (about 370 km; leave Mount Cook by 14:30).
- **Cut:** drop Mt Iron, and/or Kea Point. Both are fine to skip.

Day 6 · Thu 11 Mar · Tekapo to Queenstown

Drive: about 270 km, about 4¼ h. Sunrise 07:30, sunset 20:16 (Queenstown). Overnight: Novotel Queenstown Lakeside (Accor).

Time	What	Notes
07:40	Church of the Good Shepherd and the Tekapo lakefront	Morning light on the lake. A short walk from either Accor hotel.
08:30–09:45	Mt John summit	Drive the short summit road (it has a small toll and set gate hours, so check). It's the best 360° lookout over Lakes Tekapo and Alexandrina. Coffee at the Astro Café.
10:00	Leave via Twizel, Omarama and Lindis Pass	Fuel in Twizel or Omarama.
12:45–13:30	Cromwell: lunch	Fruit stalls, old Cromwell heritage precinct by Lake Dunstan.
13:50	Kawarau Gorge and the Kawarau Bridge viewing deck	Watch the original bungy for free from the deck.
14:20–15:10	Arrowtown	Historic gold-rush main street and the restored Chinese settlement, about 30 min of walking.
15:30	Check in, Queenstown	You won't need the car again today.
16:00–17:00	Kiwi Park Queenstown (Kiwi Birdlife Park)	Kiwi house, kea, tuatara and conservation shows, at the foot of the gondola. Check closing time. Roughly NZ$50–60 per adult.
19:00–20:30	Skyline Gondola to Bob's Peak	Walk from the hotel. Sunset over Lake Wakatipu and The Remarkables. Gondola roughly NZ$60–70 per adult return.

Day 7 · Fri 12 Mar · The Milford Road

Drive: about 410 km, about 6½ h. The second-longest day, on a slow mountain road. Sunrise 07:36 (Queenstown), sunset 20:18 (Te Anau). Overnight: Te Anau (no Accor in town).

Time	What	Notes
07:40	Leave Queenstown (SH6 to Kingston, SH94)	Leave your big bags at the Queenstown hotel if they'll store them, because you're back tomorrow night.
09:55	Te Anau: fuel	**Fill the tank.** There's no fuel on the 120 km to Milford or back.
10:40–11:00	Eglinton Valley and Mirror Lakes	The flats are a grassy valley with mountain walls. The Mirror Lakes walk is 5 min.
11:15–11:45	Lake Gunn Nature Walk (optional), Monkey Creek	Beech forest loop, about 45 min. Kea are often at Monkey Creek.
12:00	Homer Tunnel	One-lane tunnel with traffic lights, so expect up to about 15 min of waiting. Kea at the portal; don't feed them.
12:20	The Chasm	About 20 min return. The river has carved stone basins.
12:45–14:15	Milford Sound / Piopiotahi	Foreshore Walk (about 20 min) with views of Mitre Peak and waterfalls, plus a coffee. No cruise. Car parking is paid.
14:15–16:30	Drive back to Te Anau (118 km)	If you missed photo stops this morning, do them now.
16:40–17:30	Te Anau Bird Sanctuary / Punanga Manu o Te Anau	Takahē (once thought extinct) and other native birds, on the lakefront. Free entry. Lakefront stroll in the evening.

- **Cut:** skip Lake Gunn and keep the other stops short. Don't leave Milford later than 15:30.
- There's no mobile coverage on most of the Milford Road. The road can close after heavy rain or rockfall, so check NZTA conditions (journeys.nzta.govt.nz) the evening before and that morning.
- **Possible new fee:** the government plans to charge international visitors (roughly NZ$20–40 per person) at Milford Sound and Aoraki/Mount Cook. It needs a law change, and the earliest suggested start is summer 2027. It's not confirmed for March 2027, and it's unclear whether Australians will pay. Check doc.govt.nz a month before you go. A permit or park-and-ride scheme for the Milford Road is still only at the study stage.

Day 8 · Sat 13 Mar · Lake Wakatipu and the Glenorchy road

Drive: about 265 km, about 4 h. Sunrise 07:41 (Te Anau), sunset 20:12 (Queenstown). Overnight: Novotel Queenstown Lakeside (Accor).

Time	What	Notes
08:30	Leave Te Anau via Mossburn and Kingston	If you missed the bird sanctuary yesterday, visit at 08:00 first.
10:30	Devil's Staircase lookout (SH6)	Lake Wakatipu winding between mountains.
11:00	Through Queenstown onto the Glenorchy road	
11:20–11:50	Wilson Bay and Bennetts Bluff lookouts	The best lake-and-mountain view on the route.
12:15–14:00	Glenorchy: lunch and the Glenorchy Lagoon Walkway	Boardwalk with mountain reflections, about 1 h loop. Photograph the red wharf shed; no boat.
14:00–14:45	Drive back to Queenstown (46 km)	
15:00	Fill up in Frankton	Most rentals must be returned full, and airport-area fuel is cheaper than paying the refuel charge.
Afternoon	Queenstown Gardens and the lakefront on foot; pack	Do the Skyline Gondola now if weather stopped it on Day 6.

Day 9 · Sun 14 Mar · Return the car and fly

Drive: 7 km. Sunrise 07:39. No sightseeing.

Time	What	Notes
08:15	Leave the hotel	
08:30	Return the car at Queenstown Airport	Allow 15 min for inspection. Take photos of the fuel gauge and odometer.
09:00	Check in	Two hours before an international flight. A domestic flight needs about 60 min.
11:00	Flight departs	

Where to stay (8 nights, 1 room with two beds)

Book with your ALL member log-in for member rates and points. Prices are my estimates of typical March rates for a room with two beds, not quotes, so check them when you book. Choose free-cancellation rates so the plan can still change.

Night	Place	Recommended	Accor?	Typical NZ$ / night	Alternatives
1 · Sat 6 Mar	Christchurch Airport	Novotel Christchurch Airport	Yes	200–280	ibis Christchurch or Novotel Cathedral Square (in the city, 20 min drive)
2–3 · Sun 7, Mon 8 Mar	Franz Josef	Scenic Hotel Franz Josef Glacier	No: none in Glacier Country	220–300	Rainforest Retreat (motel rooms), other Franz Josef motels with twin units. Te Waonui is likely over budget.
4 · Tue 9 Mar	Wānaka	Edgewater Wanaka (lakefront)	No hotel on ALL. Oakridge Resort is Accor Vacation Club; check if it shows on all.accor.com.	230–300	Wanaka Hotel, Lakeside Wanaka apartments
5 · Wed 10 Mar	Lake Tekapo	Peppers Bluewater Resort	Yes	230–320	Mantra Lake Tekapo (Accor)
6 · Thu 11 Mar	Queenstown	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside	Yes	260–380	Mantra The Point, Peppers Beacon, Hotel St Moritz (MGallery) or Mövenpick (all Accor; the last two are usually over budget)
7 · Fri 12 Mar	Te Anau	Distinction Luxmore Hotel	No: none in Te Anau	180–280	Distinction Te Anau Hotel & Villas, Kingsgate Hotel Te Anau
8 · Sat 13 Mar	Queenstown	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside (same as night 6)	Yes	260–380	As night 6. Ask to store your big bags during the Te Anau night.

- **Accor nights: 4 of 8** (Christchurch, Tekapo, and two in Queenstown). There's no Accor hotel in Franz Josef, Fox, Mount Cook village or Te Anau, and none bookable on ALL in Wānaka.
- **Budget risk:** Queenstown in March is high season, and Novotel Lakeside may go over NZ$300. If it does, try Mantra The Point (apartment-style, often cheaper), or a good non-Accor hotel in Frankton.
- Ask each hotel for **two beds** when you book ("twin" or "2 queen"), as some room types are king-only.
- Parking: the Queenstown hotels charge for parking. In Christchurch and Tekapo it's usually free; confirm when booking.

Rental car and driving notes

- **Booking:** one-way, Christchurch Airport collection Sat 6 Mar about 15:30, Queenstown Airport drop-off Sun 14 Mar 08:30 (8 rental days). Most major brands and NZ firms run this route. The one-way fee is often low or waived because cars tend to flow south, but compare it. Choose an **automatic compact SUV or mid-size car**.
- **Licence:** a full Australian licence in English is valid in NZ for up to 12 months, so no IDP is needed. Only the named driver may drive. NZ drives on the left, as in Australia.
- **Insurance:** take zero or low-excess cover. Stone chips from gravel are common, and kea chew rubber seals and wipers.
- **Single driver:** Days 2 and 7 are the long ones (about 6½–7 h). Stop at least every 2 h, share navigation, and use the "Cut" lines rather than hurrying.
- **Road features:** many **one-lane bridges** (the smaller red arrow on the sign gives way), tight bends with advisory speeds, and slow-vehicle bays. Pull over to let queues pass. Never stop on the road for photos. The open-road limit is 100 km/h, and lower on many sections.
- **Before each day:** check road status on journeys.nzta.govt.nz (slips can close SH6 Haast Pass, SH73 Arthur's Pass and SH94 Milford Road), and the MetService forecast.

Fuel stop	Why
Christchurch (Day 1)	Start full
Hokitika (Day 2)	Top up after Arthur's Pass

Fuel stop	Why
Franz Josef or Fox, then Haast (Day 4)	About 140 km of Haast Pass with only one small pump
Wānaka (Day 4/5)	Before Lindis Pass
Twizel or Tekapo (Day 5/6)	Mount Cook village fuel is limited
Te Anau (Day 7): essential	No fuel on the 240 km Milford round trip
Frankton (Day 8)	Return the car full

What to book, and when

Item	Book by	Notes
All 8 nights of accommodation	**Now** (mid-November 2026)	Tekapo, Franz Josef and Queenstown fill up for March. Use free-cancellation rates.
One-way rental car	**Now**	Automatics and SUVs sell out. Check the one-way fee and excess cover.
Glacier scenic flight (optional)	Early February 2027	Midday Day 3, with rebooking to Day 4 08:00 if cancelled. Weather decides on the day.
Dark Sky Project tour (optional)	Early February 2027	Night of Day 5. It usually sells out.
West Coast Wildlife Centre backstage tour	A week ahead	Day 3, about 16:00. General entry can be bought on the day.
Antarctic Centre, Kiwi Park, Skyline Gondola	On the day or a day ahead	Online is often a little cheaper.
Check DOC access charges and NZTA road status	Early February, then daily	See the Day 7 note.

Rough budget for two (NZ$)

Item	Estimate	Basis
Accommodation, 8 nights	2,000 – 2,500	About NZ$250–310 average
One-way rental car, 8 days, with low-excess cover	700 – 1,200	Depends on brand and one-way fee
Fuel	450 – 550	About 2,100 km at about 8 L/100 km and about NZ$2.70–3.00/L
Parking, tolls, possible DOC access fees	50 – 250	Upper end only if the Milford and Mount Cook charges apply
Attractions (Antarctic Centre, Wildlife Centre, Kiwi Park, Gondola)	400 – 550	
Food (supermarket lunches, restaurant dinners)	1,000 – 1,400	About NZ$120–175 per day
Core total	**about 4,600 – 6,400**	
Optional: glacier flight with snow landing	+700 – 1,100	
Optional: Dark Sky Project tour	+300 – 400	

All prices are estimates from published and reseller listings and typical rates. I didn't take any live quotes.

Checked against your rules

Your rule	Result
At most 500 km in any day	Pass. Longest is Day 2 at about 440 km, then Day 7 at about 410 km.
Never drive after dark	Pass. Latest planned arrival is about 18:10 on Day 5 (sunset 20:11). No departure is before sunrise. Day 9 leaves at 08:15 (sunrise 07:39).
No boats or ferries	Pass. Milford is seen from the shore; no cruises, jet boats, glacier-lake boats or the glowworm-cave boat. The scenic flight is optional.
No beaches	Pass. Coastal views are from lookouts only (Knights Point). Lakeshore paths are not beach walks.
No walks longer than about 2 h	Pass. Longest are about 1½ h (Lake Matheson, Franz Josef valley, Hooker to the second bridge). Longer tracks are trimmed or left out.
Accor as many nights as possible, budget NZ$300	4 Accor nights out of 8, the most the route allows. Queenstown may go over NZ$300 in March; alternatives are listed.

Your rule	Result
Interests: mountains, lookouts, lakes, glaciers, wildlife	Every day has at least two of these. Wildlife: kea, kiwi (two centres), takahē, little blue penguins, fur seals.
Last day: no sightseeing	Pass. Hotel, car return, flight.

Before you go

- Download offline maps. There's no signal on large parts of Arthur's Pass, Haast Pass and the Milford Road.
- Pack insect repellent for West Coast and Fiordland sandflies, strong sunscreen (UV is fierce), a rain jacket and warm layers. Mountain mornings can be near 0 °C even in March.
- Clean and dry your hiking boots before flying (biosecurity).
- Check the DOC alerts for each walk (doc.govt.nz), especially the Franz Josef valley walk and the Hooker Valley Track. Both are affected by floods and building work at times. A new second Hooker swing bridge opened in July 2026.

Sources and method

Drive distances: OSRM routing on OpenStreetMap, run for each day's exact stop order, with a buffer added for mountain roads. Sunrise and sunset: NOAA solar algorithm for each town, NZDT. Facts checked online on 9 Nov 2026: Accor South Island hotel list (all.accor.com); DOC Hooker Valley Track page (second swing bridge opened July 2026, White Horse Hill parking NZ$2.50 per half hour); DOC "international visitor access charges" consultation page and RNZ (7 Aug 2025) on the proposed NZ$20–40 site fees; DOC and newzealand.com walk listings (Kea Point 1 h return from White Horse Hill, Fox South Side 6.4 km); newzealand.com listing for the West Coast Wildlife Centre (08:30–18:00). Attraction prices come from reseller listings and may have changed. My web search limit ran out before I could verify the flight, Dark Sky, Kiwi Park and gondola prices, so those are typical-range estimates.